



The science of beheading

200 years ago, a man slapped the severed head of Charlotte Corday and got a frown in return. <https://digit.in/may19-83>



The end of the calorie

This measure to quantify food according to how fat it will make us, is not suitable for the job <https://digit.in/may19-84>



In movies, comics and video games, some planets are not just dead chunks of rocks, but planets with a consciousness.

Aditya Madanapalle |
aditya@digit.in

In scientific terms, there is very little reason for a planet to actually evolve into a sentient being. There is a lack of competition for resources, and there is just no reason for intelligence to emerge. Even if a single organism, such as an algae were to spread across the entire surface, it would one of the most successful species even if it were at the bottom of the food chain, without any evolutionary pressures pushing it towards sentience. The most plausible route for a planet wide intelligence is the advancement of insect mounds or hives, to form a superorganism with a hivemind.

In the *Foundation* series, there is even a sentient Galaxy that evolves out of a sentient world, and is known as

Galaxia. In philosophy, the doctrine of panpsychism says that everything in the universe, even the tiniest subatomic particles, have some amount of consciousness ingrained within them. Extrapolated to the largest scales, this would mean that the entire universe itself is a single, giant consciousness.

CYBERTRON

Cybertron is a sentient planet, and is the spherical form of Primus, a cosmic singularity, which can be considered as the highest form of

intelligence. The origins of Primus is in another older Universe, one that existed before the big bang. Cybertron is the homeworld of the *Transformers*, and all the life forms on the planet are robotic. The planet spent some early days in orbit around Alpha Centauri, but then drifted through space and has no fixed location. The size of the planet keeps changing in different adaptations from being Saturn-sized to smaller than the Earth.

BALMERA

Balmera are spherical, planet sized living creatures that share a deep connection with the species that inhabit them. While the origins of the creature are unknown, the single specimen seems to be petrified. Even when im-

